Zitian Wang

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Education

Ph.D. Candidate in Economics, University of Virginia — 2021 – 2027 (expected)

Dissertation: "Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Consumer Search: Theory and Experiment"

Committee: Charles Holt, Po-Hsuan Lin, Peter Troyan, Noah Myung

M.A. in Economics, Columbia University — 2019 – 2020

B.A. in Economics and B.S. in Financial Mathematics, University of California, Los Angeles — 2015 – 2019

Research Fields

Experimental Economics, Behavioral Economics, Game Theory, Industrial Organization

Job Market Paper

1. **Wang, Z.** (2026) "Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Search: Theory and Experiment"

Working Papers

2. **Wang, Z.**, Ahmed, I., Unjitwattana, P., Xie, E.Y., Fong, M.-J. & Lin, P.-H. (2026) "Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games" **(First author)**. Revising at **European Economic Review**.
3. **Wang, Z.** (2025) "Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game" [Slides]

Conference, Seminar and Workshop Presentations

2026	Economic Science Association (ESA) North American Meeting*, ESA World Meeting, Behavioral and Experimental Economists of the Mid-Atlantic (BEEMA10), Northwestern–Kellogg Summer School in Economic Theory (Poster Session), UVA Theory/Experimental Student Workshop
2025	ESA North American Meeting, BEEMA9

(* scheduled)

Grants and Awards

Director of Graduate Studies Research Grant (US$2,000), University of Virginia	2026
Graduate School of Arts & Sciences Council Grant (US$500), University of Virginia	2026
Travel Grant, Conference on Field Experiments in Strategy (US$400), Duke University	2026

Professional Activities

Organizer

UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Student Workshop 2025 – Present
UVA Theory/Experimental Economics Reading Group 2025 – Present

Research Experience

Research assistant for Prof. Peter Troyan, University of Virginia 2026
Research assistant for Prof. Denis Nekipelov, University of Virginia 2023

Summer School Attendance

Northwestern–Kellogg Summer School in Economic Theory, Northwestern University 2026
Behavioral Game Theory Summer School, University of East Anglia 2026
Chicago School in Experimental Economics, University of Chicago 2024

Teaching

Instructor, University of Virginia

Intermediate Macroeconomics (evaluation: 4.6/5) Spring 2026, Fall 2025

Teaching Assistant, University of Virginia

Global Financial Markets Fall 2025, Fall 2024
Economics of Risk, Uncertainty, and Information Spring 2025
Intermediate Microeconomics Spring 2024
Intermediate Macroeconomics Fall 2023
Principles of Macroeconomics Spring 2023
Principles of Microeconomics Fall 2022

Teaching Assistant, Columbia University

Principles of Economics Summer 2020

Skills

Programming: Python, oTree, Stata, MATLAB, LaTeX, HTML, CSS, JavaScript
Languages: Chinese (native), English (near-native)
Certificate: CFA Level I

References

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Abstracts

1. Auction for Prominence and Price-Directed Search: Theory and Experiment

In online marketplaces, consumers spend effort searching for a good match. Such scarcity of attention motivates sellers to pay the platform to be inspected first, creating a market for search prominence. I develop a model in which two *ex ante* identical sellers bid in a second-price auction for the prominent position, which the consumer inspects for free. Sellers then post prices simultaneously. Having seen both prices and the prominent seller's match, the consumer decides whether to pay a search cost to inspect the second seller's match. I derive the search cutoff, the mixed-strategy pricing equilibrium, and sellers' willingness to pay for prominence, and test these predictions in a laboratory experiment with low- and high-search-cost treatments. As predicted, prices in the prominent position are systematically higher than those in the second position, and the gap widens as search becomes more costly. However, prices are far more dispersed than predicted, compressing the gap. Consumers broadly follow the cutoff rule, with errors in both directions after a bad initial match. Sellers overvalue prominence, as their bids exceed the realized difference in continuation values across positions under both search costs.

2. Revisiting the Intra-Team Communication Method to Elicit Level-k Reasoning in Beauty Contests and 11–20 Games

How level-0 players behave and how they are perceived by higher-level players are central questions in the literature on level-k models of boundedly rational strategic reasoning. To study these twin questions, we apply the intra-team communication method developed by Burchardi and Penczynski (2014) to identify level-0 actions and beliefs in the canonical beauty contest game and in a variant of the 11–20 game of Goeree et al. (2018), in which behavior appears inconsistent with the standard level-k model. In the beauty contest game, we replicate Burchardi and Penczynski (2014)'s finding that elicited level-0 beliefs align with observed level-0 actions. In the variant of the 11–20 game, however, elicited level-0 beliefs and observed level-0 actions diverge, and both depart from the standard level-0 assumption, suggesting a complementary explanation for the behavioral pattern documented by Goeree et al. (2018).

3. Coordination under Uncertainty and Noisy Communication: A Generalized Email Game

Which information transmission protocols improve coordination under uncertainty and noisy communication? Theory is indeterminate between an inefficient "tacit" equilibrium, where information is ignored, and an efficient "vocal" equilibrium, where players act on it. We test this in a laboratory experiment based on a generalized email game, exogenously varying the message-generation rule across three protocols. Vocal behavior rises with the incentive to take the risky action, and relative to an automatic protocol, voluntary messaging significantly improves coordination. However, a sunk cost to sending reduces vocality by inducing senders to opt out. These patterns suggest that voluntariness credibly signals players' intent to coordinate via forward induction, and that the value of cost-free signaling for equilibrium selection hinges on the alignment of interests.